# HongSeok Kim

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## Education

**Iowa State University** — Ames, IA
Ph.D. in Economics — 2021 – 2027 (expected)

Dissertation Committee: Juan Carlos Córdoba (Chair), Rajesh Singh, Quinn Weninger, Sergio Lence, and Jian Li

**Hanyang University** — Seoul, Republic of Korea
M.A. in Economics and Finance — 2021
B.A. in Economics and Finance — 2019

## Research Interests

Macroeconomics, Public Economics, Economics of Aging

## Job Market Paper

**Constrained-Optimal Pension Benefit Rules under Debt Ceilings**

Abstract. The value of a pension promise depends on the taxes required to finance it. I study constrained-optimal pension benefit rules in a general equilibrium model with overlapping generations, calibrated to the U.S. economy in 2010. Households choose saving and labor hours, work builds skills, and the government finances shortfalls through borrowing and consumption taxes. At each debt ceiling, I compare alternative pension benefit rules with a reference rule that limits benefits to available program funding. I find that the welfare losses to future generations from maintaining full pension benefits exceed the gains to current adults. The welfare cost is larger in the specification with learning by doing, where consumption taxes have distortionary effects on work and weaken skill accumulation. For U.S. Social Security, the speed of benefit reductions introduces another trade-off. Conditional on a benefit level, gradual cuts can improve welfare by protecting existing cohorts, while further delay reduces gains for future entrants. When both benefits and payroll taxes change, ten-year benefit cuts paired with a twenty-year payroll tax increase yield the highest welfare. Benefit and tax adjustment speeds must therefore be chosen jointly.

## Working Papers

**The Intergenerational Welfare Cost of Social Security Insolvency** [Link]

Abstract. This paper asks which generations bear the welfare cost of Social Security insolvency. The trust fund is expected to be depleted in 2033, but each generation meets it at a different age, with different years of benefits at stake and different means of adjusting. In a life-cycle model with endogenous saving, labor supply, human capital, and claiming, I quantify how the expected duration of reduced payments shifts that welfare incidence. The main result is that the cohort losing the most unpaid dollars is not the cohort losing the most welfare. Households that expect the shortfall self-insure by saving, working, and human-capital investment, but the cost of doing so depends on age. The youngest cohorts spread the adjustment over a career, whereas mid-career cohorts must compress it into the years before retirement and end up worse off than if the shortfall had been a surprise. Duration matters as well. When the shortfall is brief, the burden lands mainly on retirees, and when it is prolonged, the burden shifts to the working generations behind them.

**Fertility Inertia under Ambiguity Aversion** [Link]

Abstract. High family-policy spending often produces only small changes in fertility. I study this problem in a Barro–Becker model. Parents value descendants' utility, dislike risk in its total value, and assess family plans by their worst-case value. They are uncertain about how well public news predicts children's outcomes. Information inertia creates an interval of bad news in which welfare falls but locally optimal fertility, investment per child, and consumption remain unchanged. Reliable subsidies can still raise fertility. An explicit policy solution discounts uncertain benefits by the lowest possible delivery rate. Thus, unclear delivery requires larger promises for the same fertility response. More effective support raises fertility and shifts and widens the inertia interval. Less uncertainty about signal informativeness narrows it for a fixed family plan. This suggests two policy dimensions: generosity and legibility. The exact inertia result is limited to maxmin preferences, continuous fertility, and a local normal representation.

## Work in Progress

**Optimal Immigration Policy under Private Information: A Macroeconomic Approach**

**Insurance and Learning about Self-Protection: Evidence from Conservation Reserve Program**
(with Hyewon Lee)

## Fellowships, Honors, and Awards

| | |
|---|---|
| Graduate Teaching Excellence Award (Top 10%), Iowa State University | 2026 |
| Professional Advancement Grant (PAG), Iowa State University | 2026 |
| Graduate Student Workshop Fellowship, Western Economic Association International | 2026 |
| Summer Teaching Assistantship, Iowa State University | 2025 |
| Most Engaging Presentation Award, EGSA, Iowa State University | 2025 |
| Best Discussant Award, EGSA, Iowa State University | 2025 |
| Research Travel Grant ($750) × 6, Iowa State University | 2023 – 2026 |
| Brain Korea 21 Plus Scholarship, Hanyang University | 2020 – 2021 |
| HY-IN Graduate School Academic Scholarship, Hanyang University | 2020 |
| Korea Student Aid Foundation Academic Fellowship | 2019 |
| Graduation Award, Hanyang University | 2019 |

## Teaching Experience

**Sole Instructor**

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|---|---|---|---|---|
| ECON 1020 | Principles of Macroeconomics | Undergrad | Summer 2025 | 4.36 |

**Recitation Instructor – Graduate**

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|---|---|---|---|---|
| ECON 6040 | Advanced Macroeconomic Analysis | Ph.D. core | Spring 2024, 2025, 2026 | 5.00 |
| ECON 6020 | Macroeconomic Analysis | Ph.D. core | Fall 2025 | 5.00 |
| ECON 6030 | Advanced Microeconomics – Game Theory | Ph.D. core | Spring 2023 | 4.67 |
| ECON 5710 | Intermediate Econometrics | Master's | Spring 2026 | 4.50 |
| ECON 5000 | Quantitative Methods in Economic Analysis I | Master's | Fall 2026 | |

**Teaching Assistant / Lab Instructor – Undergraduate**

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|---|---|---|---|---|
| ECON 3020 | Intermediate Macroeconomics | Undergrad | 2025 | 5.00 |
| ECON 3710 | Introduction to Econometrics | Undergrad | 2021 | 4.29 |
| ECON 1020 | Principles of Macroeconomics | Undergrad | 2022–2025 | |
| ECON 1010 | Principles of Microeconomics | Undergrad | 2021, 2023, 2024 | |

## Presentations, Conferences, and Workshops

([†]Scheduled)

**2026:** 96th Southern Economic Association (Houston)[†], Midwest Macro Fall Meetings (Texas Tech)[†], 21st Economics Graduate Student Conference (Washington University in St. Louis), Econometric Society Conference on Dynamic Structural Econometrics (University of Michigan), 101st Western Economic Association International, North American Summer Meeting of the Econometric Society (Emory University), Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society (Vietnam; accepted, cancelled)

**2025:** Workshop on AI and Machine Learning for Economists (Iowa State University)

**2024:** Southern Economic Association (Washington, D.C.), 19th Economics Graduate Student Conference (Washington University in St. Louis), Midwest Macro Fall Meetings (Purdue University), Macro Reading Group (Iowa State University)

**2023:** Midwest Economic Association (Chicago)

## Academic Service

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| Discussant, "Urbanicity and Fertility: Evidence from Refugees to Canada," MEA, Chicago | 2024 |
| Guest Lecture, ECON 3270: Quantity–Quality Trade-off in Becker's Model | 2025 |
| Economics Help Room Services for Undergraduates, Iowa State University | 2021, 2023 |

## Skills and Additional Information

**Software:** Fortran (OpenMP/MPI), Python, Julia, Stata

**Citizenship:** Republic of Korea (F-1 visa)

## References

**Juan Carlos Córdoba**
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